

HYDERABAD AIRPORT Modernised 2008

With a 4.26-km runway, the second-longest in Asia, a built-up area of 105,300 sq m and a capacity of 12 million passengers a year, the airport will ultimately cover 900,000 sq m and cater to 40 million passengers a year

TAKEOFF TRIUMPH

With snazzy glass surfaces and metal cladding covering no less than 20,000 sq m, the Rs 2,478-crore Rajiv Gandhi International Airport (RGIA) is India's first truly world class airport. Conceived by Gudmund Stokke, who designed Oslo airport, RGIA's detailed designs were prepared by Winston Shu who created the Hong Kong International Airport on paper.

Having opened in March last year, the airport works as well as it looks. A modern passenger management system translates into 130 check-in counters and 16 self-check kiosks. Bags are screened by an in-line screening system as they move along conveyor belts. Immigration clearance is quick too, with an enthusiastic staff. The world beyond the security check has a choice of cafes and restaurants, among them the Hard Rock Café and the IIFA bar.

The passenger terminal building made by the China State Construction Engineering (Hong Kong) Limited is

modelled on Kuala Lumpur's airport that makes use of natural light. Spread over 105,300 sq m, it can handle 12 million passengers a year. Ultimately, the total built-up area of the airport will be 900,000 sq m and it will cater to over 40 million passengers a year. Nearly 75 per cent of the aircraft parked in the terminal have access to passenger boarding bridges—a facility that is not possible at any other airport in the country now. The 4.26-km runway, the second-longest in Asia, and the terminal will accommodate the Airbus A380, the world's largest passenger aircraft. The Air Traffic Control tower is the tallest in the country at 75 m.

GMR Hyderabad International Airport Limited (GHIAL) opened RGIA five months ahead of

schedule. GHIAL capitalised in absorbing the best global practices by benchmarking the project according to global norms and forging an alliance with Malaysia Airport Holdings Berhad. Grandhi Mallikarjuna Rao—the founding patriarch of GMR Infrastructure Limited—is making sure that there will be no long gestation. GHIAL wants to buck the national trend of relying on aeronautical streams of revenue, forced by decades of government control, and turn to non-aero streams for quicker and steady cash flow, the international

trend. "Despite the recession, there are over 350 aircraft in operation in India. We expect more than 200 new aircraft in a few years, with a possible increase of 2,000 new planes in the next 10 to 15 years," says P. Sripathy.

GHIAL plans to transform the RGIA gateway into an airport city. Beginning with the Rs 1,500-crore GMR Aerospace Park, the

emerging airport city will have luxury hotels, theme parks, golf courses, concert halls and industrial parks that were till now considered unsuitable for an airport. It has already a 305-room business class Novotel hotel with conferencing facilities. Finally, value for your money. *by Amarnath K. Menon*

100 million passengers is the mark the Indian civil aviation market is expected to touch by 2010. It ranks ninth in the world.



"Our robust planning gave us the ability to anticipate and scale up based on traffic estimates and growing passenger capacity at the old airport in Begumpet."

P. Sripathy 56, CEO